

▶ GUJARAT

A METAL STEED TO DHOLERA

Gujarat gets its second marquee rail project: India's first semi high-speed train line, linking to a new industrial hub

By **Jumana Shah**

A **DECADE ON, THE BULLET TRAIN PROJECT** between Mumbai and Ahmedabad may be moving like a Cupid's arrow in a slow-motion dream, but Gujarat has got recompense. After a Union cabinet nod, it has secured a second marquee rail project. India's first semi high-speed corridor, it will run the 134 km between the Ahmedabad suburb of Sarkhej and Dholera, a coastal town due southwest in the Gulf of Khambat. That destination is a place fast gathering importance. The planned line itself is evidence: it will operate at 200 kmph, with a design speed of 220 kmph, both the highest yet for an Indian train.

Built on indigenous technology and running parallel to the Ahmedabad-Dholera Expressway, the semi high-speed train will carry both passengers and freight, integrating with Western Railway's existing network in Ahmedabad at one end. The other end—of what's being planned as a full-fledged infrastructure corridor—is set to bloom as the Dholera Special Investment Region (DSIR), India's first planned greenfield industrial smart city designed as a commercial, semiconductor and manufacturing hub. If all goes to plan, the line will be operational by 2030-31, serving as what the ministry of railways describes as a reference model for a phased national rollout.

The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs cleared the project at Rs 20,667 crore on May 13. The 134-km line is double-tracked, with a total track length of 293 km and 13 stations, including spurs of eight km to the Lothal Maritime Heritage Complex and 17 km to the Dholera International Airport. Beyond Dholera, the line extends to Bavaliyari, from where a separate 65-km extension to Bhavnagar is under survey.

'LARGER THAN SINGAPORE'

The engineering load is heavy: 74 km of viaducts, three mega bridges, 39 road-under-bridges and two rail-over-rail crossings. Union home minister Amit Shah, in whose Gandhinagar constituency much of the alignment falls, called